



FAITH FOUNDATIONS STUDY SERIES

Bible Stories & Application Study Workbook

Timeless Bible Narratives and What They Mean for Your Life Today -
For Teens & Young Adults

Written by Daniel Tesfamariam



Ages 13-19 - Homeschool & Youth Groups

Personal Study - Small Groups - Reproducible for one household or class



HOW TO USE THIS STUDY

Getting the Most From This Workbook

This study takes six well-known Bible narratives and moves past the flannel-board version you heard as a kid. For ages 13 to 19, each unit asks what the story reveals about God and what it demands of you now. Read, wrestle, journal, and apply.

ROMANS 15:4

"Everything that was written in the past was written to teach us."

A Few Suggestions

- ☐ Find a consistent time and place. Even 15 focused minutes beats an hour you never start.
- ☐ Keep a pen in hand. Writing your answers turns reading into real thinking.
- ☐ Read each passage in your own Bible too, and note the version differences.
- ☐ Be honest in the reflection and journal sections - no one is grading you.
- ☐ If you meet with a group, come having already written your answers.
- ☐ Pray before you begin. Ask God to teach you, not just inform you.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

What's Inside

- 1 How to Use This Study
- 2 Table of Contents
- 3 **Unit 1: Joseph: Trusting God in the Dark**
- 4 **Unit 2: Ruth: Loyalty and Belonging**
- 5 **Unit 3: David and Goliath: Facing Giants**
- 6 **Unit 4: The Prodigal Son: Coming Home**
- 7 **Unit 5: Esther: Courage for Such a Time**
- 8 **Unit 6: Jesus: The Story's Center**
- 9 Memory Verse Review
- 10 Spiritual Check-In
- 11 Final Reflection
- 12 Study Notes

UNIT 1

Joseph: Trusting God in the Dark

"You intended to harm me, but God intended it for good." - Genesis 50:20

Unit Overview

Joseph was betrayed, enslaved, and imprisoned before he was elevated. His story teaches how God works through injustice we cannot yet understand.

DEVOTIONAL

When Life Isn't Fair

Few teens escape the feeling that life is unfair. Joseph lived it to the extreme - and still trusted God.

GENESIS 50:20

"You intended to harm me, but God intended it for good, to accomplish the saving of many lives."

Joseph does not pretend his brothers were kind; he names the harm. Yet he sees a bigger hand at work behind it.

Trusting God does not mean calling evil good. It means believing God can redeem even what was meant to destroy you.

Reflect

1. What situation feels unfair to you right now?

2. Can you imagine God bringing something good out of it - even if you can't see how yet?

PRAYER PROMPT

God, help me trust you in the parts of my story I don't understand.

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - OBSERVE

Betrayed but Not Abandoned

Read the passage slowly, more than once. First notice what it actually says before deciding what it means.

GENESIS 39:20-23

"Joseph's master took him and put him in prison, the place where the king's prisoners were confined. But while Joseph was there in the prison, the Lord was with him; he showed him kindness and granted him favor in the eyes of the prison warden. So the warden put Joseph in charge of all those held in the prison."

Observation - What does it say?

1. Where is Joseph in this passage?

2. What phrase is repeated about the Lord?

3. What happens even in prison?

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - INTERPRET & APPLY

Betrayed but Not Abandoned

Interpretation - What does it mean?

1. How can God be 'with' someone who is suffering unjustly?

2. What does Joseph's response to prison reveal about his character?

Application - What will I do?

1. Where do you need to remember God is 'with you' right now?

2. How can you act with integrity even in an unfair situation?

WORD STUDY

Providence

MEANING

God's wise, ongoing care that guides all events toward his good purposes, even through human evil and ordinary circumstances.

Where It Appears**ROMANS 8:28**

"In all things God works for the good of those who love him."

PROVERBS 16:4

"The Lord works out everything to its proper end."

Dig Deeper

1. How is providence different from luck or fate?

2. Where have you looked back and seen God's hand in something painful?

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

My Unfair Chapter

Write about a time you were treated unfairly.

How did you respond? How do you wish you had responded?

What would it look like to trust God with that memory now?

FAITH & WORLDVIEW

Does God Cause Evil?

THE QUESTION

If God is in control, is he responsible for the bad things people do?

Think It Through**Human responsibility**

The brothers freely chose to harm Joseph; God did not force their sin.

Divine redemption

God did not author the evil, but he wove it into a plan for good.

Mystery held with trust

The Bible holds both truths without fully explaining the mechanics.

Your Response

1. How does Joseph hold both human evil and God's goodness together?

2. What is the difference between God causing evil and God redeeming it?

UNIT 2

Ruth: Loyalty and Belonging

"Where you go I will go, and where you stay I will stay." - Ruth 1:16

Unit Overview

Ruth, an outsider and a widow, chose loyalty and faith. Her story is about commitment, identity, and how God includes the overlooked.

DEVOTIONAL

Choosing to Stay

Ruth had every reason to walk away and start over. She chose loyalty instead.

RUTH 1:16

"Your people will be my people and your God my God."

Ruth's famous words were not spoken at a wedding but to a grieving mother-in-law with nothing to offer her.

Real commitment shows up when leaving would be easier and no one would blame you for it.

Reflect

1. Where is loyalty hard for you right now?

2. Who in your life needs you to choose to stay?

PRAYER PROMPT

Lord, make me the kind of person who keeps commitments when it costs me.

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - OBSERVE

Faithful in the Fields

Read the passage slowly, more than once. First notice what it actually says before deciding what it means.

RUTH 2:11-12

"Boaz replied, 'I've been told all about what you have done for your mother-in-law since the death of your husband - how you left your father and mother and your homeland and came to live with a people you did not know before. May the Lord repay you for what you have done. May you be richly rewarded by the Lord, the God of Israel, under whose wings you have come to take refuge.'"

Observation - What does it say?

1. What has Boaz heard about Ruth?

2. What did Ruth leave behind?

3. How does Boaz describe God?

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - INTERPRET & APPLY

Faithful in the Fields

Interpretation - What does it mean?

1. Why does Ruth's reputation precede her?

2. What does 'taking refuge under God's wings' mean?

Application - What will I do?

1. What reputation are your actions building?

2. Where do you need to 'take refuge' in God?

WORD STUDY

Kindness (Hesed)

MEANING

The Hebrew word hesed means loyal, covenant love - kindness that keeps its promises and does not quit.

Where It Appears**PROVERBS 3:3**

"Let love and faithfulness never leave you."

PSALM 136:1

"His love (hesed) endures forever."

Dig Deeper

1. How is hesed different from being merely nice?

2. Who has shown you loyal love, and how can you pass it on?

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

Where I Belong


Have you ever felt like an outsider? Describe it.


How does it change things to know God includes the overlooked?


Who around you feels like an outsider that you could welcome?

SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Talk It Over

Ruth's story is quiet but powerful. Dig into loyalty and belonging together.

1. What makes loyalty so rare today?

2. Where have you seen God use an 'unlikely' person?

3. How can this group be a place of belonging?

UNIT 3

David and Goliath: Facing Giants

"The battle is the Lord's." - 1 Samuel 17:47

Unit Overview

The famous story is less about a slingshot and more about where our confidence comes from when we face things far bigger than us.

DEVOTIONAL

Naming Your Giants

Everyone faces giants - fears and pressures that feel unbeatable. The question is whose eyes you use to size them up.

1 SAMUEL 17:37

"The Lord who rescued me from the paw of the lion and the paw of the bear will rescue me from the hand of this Philistine."

David's courage came from memory: he recalled past rescues to face a present threat.

Everyone else measured Goliath against themselves. David measured Goliath against God.

Reflect

1. What 'giant' feels unbeatable to you right now?

2. What past faithfulness of God can you remember to build courage?

PRAYER PROMPT

God, help me see my giants next to you, not next to me.

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - OBSERVE

Confidence in the Lord

Read the passage slowly, more than once. First notice what it actually says before deciding what it means.

1 SAMUEL 17:45-47

"David said to the Philistine, 'You come against me with sword and spear and javelin, but I come against you in the name of the Lord Almighty, the God of the armies of Israel, whom you have defied. This day the Lord will deliver you into my hands... All those gathered here will know that it is not by sword or spear that the Lord saves; for the battle is the Lord's.'"

Observation - What does it say?

1. What weapons does Goliath rely on?

2. What does David come in the name of?

3. Whose battle is it?

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - INTERPRET & APPLY

Confidence in the Lord

Interpretation - What does it mean?

1. Why does David make it about God's reputation, not his own?

2. What does 'the battle is the Lord's' mean practically?

Application - What will I do?

1. What are you trying to win in your own strength?

2. How would today change if you saw the battle as God's?

WORD STUDY

Courage

MEANING

Not the absence of fear, but acting rightly in spite of fear because of confidence in God.

Where It Appears**DEUTERONOMY 31:6**

"Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; the Lord your God goes with you."

JOSHUA 1:9

"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous."

Dig Deeper

1. How is biblical courage different from being fearless?

2. What is one courageous, God-honoring step you have been avoiding?

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

My Giants

List the 'giants' you are currently facing.

Which one scares you most, and why?

What would it look like to face it trusting God?

APPLICATION CHALLENGE

Face One Giant

Courage grows by use. Take one real step this week.

This Week's Challenges

- ☐ Have one hard conversation you have been avoiding.
- ☐ Do one right thing that will cost you socially.
- ☐ Pray specifically about your biggest fear every day this week.
- ☐ Ask a trusted adult for help with something you can't face alone.

What happened when you tried?

UNIT 4

The Prodigal Son: Coming Home

"This son of mine was dead and is alive again." - Luke 15:24

Unit Overview

Jesus' most famous parable is about running away, hitting bottom, and a father who runs to welcome us back. It reframes how we see God.

DEVOTIONAL

The Father Who Runs

Whether you feel like the wild younger son or the resentful older one, this story is about you.

LUKE 15:20

"But while he was still a long way off, his father saw him and was filled with compassion for him; he ran to his son."

In that culture, dignified men did not run. The father's running was scandalous grace.

The son rehearsed a speech to earn his way back; the father interrupted it with a robe and a ring. Grace is not earned.

Reflect

1. Do you relate more to the younger son or the older brother right now?

2. What do you think you have to do to earn God's acceptance?

PRAYER PROMPT

Father, thank you that you run toward me. Help me come home.

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - OBSERVE

Lost and Found

Read the passage slowly, more than once. First notice what it actually says before deciding what it means.

LUKE 15:17-24

"When he came to his senses, he said, 'How many of my father's hired servants have food to spare, and here I am starving to death! I will set out and go back to my father.' ... But the father said to his servants, 'Quick! Bring the best robe and put it on him. Put a ring on his finger and sandals on his feet. Let's have a feast and celebrate. For this son of mine was dead and is alive again; he was lost and is found.'"

Observation - What does it say?

1. What causes the son to change direction?

2. What does he plan to say?

3. How does the father respond before the son can finish?

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - INTERPRET & APPLY

Lost and Found

Interpretation - What does it mean?

1. What does 'coming to his senses' mean spiritually?

2. Why does the father celebrate instead of lecture?

Application - What will I do?

1. What would 'coming to your senses' look like for you?

2. What do you need to stop trying to earn?

WORD STUDY

Grace

MEANING

Undeserved favor - God's kindness given freely to people who could never earn it.

Where It Appears**EPHESIANS 2:8**

"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith."

ROMANS 5:20

"Where sin increased, grace increased all the more."

Dig Deeper

1. Why is grace so hard for us to accept?

2. How does receiving grace change how you treat others?

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

Coming Home

Is there an area where you have wandered from God?

What holds you back from coming home to him?

Write the 'father running toward you' in your own words.

FAITH & WORLDVIEW

Isn't Christianity Just a Crutch?

THE QUESTION

Is faith only for weak people who can't cope on their own?

Think It Through**Everyone leans on something**

Money, status, and relationships are also 'crutches' people trust for meaning.

Honesty about need

Christianity starts by admitting we all need help - that is realism, not weakness.

Strength to serve

Faith has driven believers to hospitals, abolition, and sacrifice, not just comfort.

Your Response

1. What do people around you lean on for meaning?

2. How would you respond to a friend who calls faith a crutch?

UNIT 5

Esther: Courage for Such a Time

"And who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?" - Esther 4:14

Unit Overview

Esther risked her life to speak up for her people. Her story is about using your position, however small, for good at the right moment.

DEVOTIONAL

For Such a Time as This

You did not end up in your family, school, or friend group by accident. God places people on purpose.

ESTHER 4:14

"If you remain silent at this time, relief and deliverance for the Jews will arise from another place... And who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?"

Esther could have stayed safe and silent. Mordecai reminds her that safety is not the same as purpose.

God does not need you - but he chooses to use you. That is dignity, not pressure.

Reflect

1. Where has God placed you that others cannot easily reach?

2. Is there something you have stayed silent about that you should speak up on?

PRAYER PROMPT

God, give me courage to use where you have placed me for good.

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - OBSERVE

Risking It All

Read the passage slowly, more than once. First notice what it actually says before deciding what it means.

ESTHER 4:15-17

"Then Esther sent this reply to Mordecai: 'Go, gather together all the Jews who are in Susa, and fast for me. Do not eat or drink for three days, night or day. I and my attendants will fast as you do. When this is done, I will go to the king, even though it is against the law. And if I perish, I perish.'"

Observation - What does it say?

1. What does Esther ask others to do first?

2. What law is she about to break?

3. What is her final resolve?

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - INTERPRET & APPLY

Risking It All

Interpretation - What does it mean?

1. Why does Esther call for fasting before acting?

2. What does 'if I perish, I perish' reveal about her?

Application - What will I do?

1. What do you need to pray and fast about before you act?

2. Where do you need Esther-level resolve?

WORD STUDY

Providence

MEANING

God's unseen guidance of events. God is never named in Esther, yet his hand is on every 'coincidence.'

Where It Appears**PROVERBS 21:1**

"The king's heart is in the hand of the Lord."

PROVERBS 19:21

"Many are the plans in a person's heart, but it is the Lord's purpose that prevails."

Dig Deeper

1. Why might God be at work even when he seems 'absent'?

2. Where have you seen 'coincidences' that were maybe more than that?

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

My Position, My Moment


What influence do you have that you tend to overlook?


Is there a right thing you have been too scared to do?


What would courage look like this week?

SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

Talk It Over

Esther's story pushes us from safety to purpose. Discuss honestly.

1. Where do we stay silent when we should speak?

2. How do we tell the difference between wise caution and fear?

3. How can this group support each other in doing hard, right things?

UNIT 6

Jesus: The Story's Center

"I am the way and the truth and the life." - John 14:6

Unit Overview

Every earlier story points here. This unit looks at who Jesus claimed to be and what it means to follow him, not just admire him.

DEVOTIONAL

More Than a Good Teacher

Most people are happy to call Jesus a good teacher. His own claims make that a hard place to stop.

JOHN 14:6

"I am the way and the truth and the life. No one comes to the Father except through me."

A merely good teacher does not claim to be the only way to God. Jesus repeatedly did.

That leaves fewer options than we like: he was either lying, deluded, or telling the truth. 'Nice teacher' isn't really on the menu.

Reflect

1. Who have you tended to believe Jesus is?

2. What would change if his claims about himself are actually true?

PRAYER PROMPT

Jesus, show me who you really are, and help me follow, not just admire, you.

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - OBSERVE

The Great Invitation

Read the passage slowly, more than once. First notice what it actually says before deciding what it means.

MATTHEW 11:28-30

"Come to me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you and learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For my yoke is easy and my burden is light."

Observation - What does it say?

1. Who is invited to come?

2. What does Jesus promise to give?

3. How does he describe himself?

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY - INTERPRET & APPLY

The Great Invitation

Interpretation - What does it mean?

1. What is a 'yoke,' and why is following Jesus described that way?

2. How can a yoke bring rest?

Application - What will I do?

1. What are you weary and burdened by right now?

2. What would it look like to bring that to Jesus this week?

WORD STUDY

Disciple

MEANING

A learner and follower who orders their whole life around a teacher. To follow Jesus is to become his apprentice.

Where It Appears**JOHN 8:31**

"If you hold to my teaching, you are really my disciples."

MATTHEW 28:19

"Go and make disciples of all nations."

Dig Deeper

1. What is the difference between a fan and a disciple?

2. What area of your life have you not yet let Jesus 'teach'?

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

Following, Not Just Admiring

Where have you kept Jesus as an admired figure rather than a followed Lord?

What would fully following him cost you?

What is one step of real discipleship you will take?

APPLICATION CHALLENGE

Follow This Week

Discipleship is practiced, not just believed. Choose concrete steps.

This Week's Challenges

- ☐ Read one Gospel account of Jesus each day this week.
- ☐ Do one thing Jesus commands that stretches you.
- ☐ Tell one person something true about who Jesus is.
- ☐ Bring one real burden to Jesus in prayer each day.

What happened when you tried?

MEMORY & MEDITATION

Hide This Word in Your Heart

GENESIS 50:20

"Genesis 50:20"

Context

Look back over the verses you studied in this book.

Why It Matters

Scripture memorized becomes a resource the Holy Spirit can bring to mind in real moments of decision, temptation, doubt, and encouragement.

Write It From Memory

LIVE IT OUT THIS WEEK

Choose one verse from this book to carry with you all week.

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

Memory Verse Review

Write out from memory: Genesis 50:20

Write out from memory: Ruth 1:16

Write out from memory: 1 Samuel 17:47

Write out from memory: Luke 15:24

Write out from memory: John 14:6

SELF-ASSESSMENT

Spiritual Check-In

Rate each statement honestly. This is between you and God - there are no wrong answers, only honest starting points.

1 = rarely 5 = consistently

I make time to read the Bible on my own.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

I pray about real things in my life, not just at meals.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

I can explain what I believe and why.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

I treat people the way Jesus would.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

I invite God into my decisions before I make them.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

I am honest even when it costs me.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

I serve others without expecting anything back.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

I go to God first when I am anxious or afraid.

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

REFLECTION & JOURNAL

Final Reflection

Which Bible story spoke to you most, and why?

How has your view of God changed through these stories?

Write a prayer response to what you've learned.

NOTES

Study Notes

NOTES

Study Notes